

INSTALLATION GUIDE FOR LEGALEASE PROJECT

Online Legal Services Platform

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Project: LegalEase – a web platform that connects customers with verified lawyers for searching, booking and managing legal consultations.

Document: Installation Guide – Version 1.0 – Semester 1 Course Project.

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A. SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

Sr.	Item	Description
1.	Operating system	Windows 7, 8, 10, 11 or higher (macOS / Linux also supported by XAMPP)
2.	Hardware	Dual-core CPU or better, 2 GB of RAM or better, 500 MB free disk space
3.	Web server package	XAMPP 8.x (Apache 2.4 + PHP 7.4 / 8.x + MySQL 8.0 or MariaDB 10.4+)
4.	Database	MySQL 8.0 / MariaDB, managed through phpMyAdmin
5.	Browser	Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge or Mozilla Firefox (latest version)
6.	Fonts	Standard Unicode fonts: Arial, Tahoma, Segoe UI, etc.
7.	Other requirement	A working internet connection (Bootstrap / jQuery CDN and Google Maps embed)

Notes: Do not install IDEs (Integrated Development Environment) on the evaluation system such as MS Visual Code, Dreamweaver, NetBeans, etc. XAMPP alone is enough to run LegalEase, because the project is written in plain PHP and does not need Composer, Node.js or any build step.

B. PACKAGE CONTENTS

After unzipping the submitted package you should see the following folders:

Folder / File	Description
SourceCode/legalease/	The complete web application (PHP, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, images)
TableScript/legalproject1.sql	MySQL script that creates the database schema and the demo data (18 tables)
Documentation/	Final documentation, Installation Guide and User Guide
README.md	Short project description and team member list

*Note: if your team renamed the SQL file, use that name in Step 3 below. The database schema name used by the application is **legalproject1**.*

C. PROGRAM INSTALLATION

Step 1. Install and start XAMPP

1. Download XAMPP from <https://www.apachefriends.org> and install it with the default options (the default installation folder on Windows is C:\xampp).
2. Open the **XAMPP Control Panel**.
3. Click **Start** next to **Apache** and **Start** next to **MySQL**. Both modules must turn green before you continue.

[Screenshot 1: XAMPP Control Panel with Apache and MySQL running]

If Apache does not start: port 80 is probably used by another program (Skype, IIS, VMware). Click Config → httpd.conf and change Listen 80 to Listen 8080, then open the site at <http://localhost:8080/> instead.

Step 2. Copy the source code into htdocs

1. Download the project from the GitHub repository:

<https://github.com/<your-account>/LegalEase-eProjectSem1>

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2. Click the green **Code** button, choose **Download ZIP**, then unzip the file.

[Screenshot 2: GitHub repository page with the Code → Download ZIP menu open]

3. Copy the folder **legalease** (the folder that contains index.php) into the XAMPP web root:

```
C:\xampp\htdocs\legalease
```

4. Confirm that the path **C:\xampp\htdocs\legalease\index.php** exists. If you see an extra folder level such as `htdocs\legalease\legalease`, move the files one level up.

Step 3. Create and import the database

1. In the XAMPP Control Panel click **Admin** next to MySQL, or open the browser at:

```
http://localhost/phpmyadmin
```

2. Click the **Databases** tab. In the *Create database* box type the name **legalproject1**, choose the collation **utf8mb4_unicode_ci** and click **Create**.

[Screenshot 3: phpMyAdmin - creating the database legalproject1]

3. Select the new database **legalproject1** in the left panel, then click the **Import** tab.
4. Click **Choose File** and select **legalproject1.sql** inside the folder **TableScript**. Leave the character set as *utf-8* and the format as *SQL*.
5. Scroll down and click **Import**. Wait for the green success message.

[Screenshot 4: phpMyAdmin - Import tab with the .sql file selected]

6. Click the database name and confirm that **18 tables** were created, for example *users*, *customer_profiles*, *lawyer_profiles*, *lawyer_verifications*, *locations*, *specializations*, *lawyer_specialties*, *availability_slots*, *appointments*, *payments*, *refunds*, *reviews*, *notifications*, *email_outbox*, *content_management*, *site_content*, *system_audit_logs*, *password_reset_tokens*.

[Screenshot 5: Table list of the legalproject1 database]

Step 4. Configure the database connection

1. Open the file **config/database.php** inside the project folder with Notepad or any plain text editor.
2. Check that the connection values match your XAMPP installation. The default XAMPP account is *root* with an empty password:

```
$host      = 'localhost';
$dbname    = 'legalproject1';
$username  = 'root';
$password  = '';
$charset   = 'utf8mb4';
```

3. Save the file. If you set a MySQL root password during installation, type that password in **\$password**.

Step 5. Run the application

1. Open your browser and go to:

```
http://localhost/legalease/
```

2. The LegalEase home page appears with the search bar, the *Featured verified lawyers* carousel and the *Legal News* section.
3. Click **Login** and sign in with one of the demo accounts in section D to verify that the three portals (Customer, Lawyer, Admin) open correctly.

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Step 6. Check the file upload folders (optional)

The application saves avatars and verification documents inside the **uploads/** folder. Make sure this folder exists and is writable. On Windows it works by default; on Linux or macOS run:

```
chmod -R 755 uploads/
```

D. DEFAULT DEMO ACCOUNTS

The imported script already contains sample data so the reviewer can test every role immediately.

Role	Email	Password	What you can test
Administrator	admin@legalease.com	123456	Dashboard, lawyer approval, user management, appointment oversight, reports, content management
Lawyer	lawyer@gmail.com	123456	Profile, verification, work schedule, appointment requests, earnings
Customer	tantuyen@gmail.com	123456	Search lawyers, book and pay for an appointment, review, notifications

*These accounts are for demonstration only. Passwords are stored as hashes in the **users** table.*

E. TROUBLESHOOTING

Problem	Cause	Solution
Apache will not start	Port 80 or 443 is already in use	Stop Skype / IIS / VMware, or change the Apache port to 8080 in httpd.conf
MySQL will not start	Port 3306 is used by another MySQL service	Stop the other MySQL service in Windows Services, then start MySQL from XAMPP again
Object not found! Error 404	The project folder is not in htdocs or the name is different	Confirm the path C:\xampp\htdocs\legalease\index.php and use the same folder name in the URL
Connection failed / Unknown database	The database was not imported or the name does not match	Re-import legalproject1.sql and check \$dbname in config/database.php
Blank white page	A PHP error is hidden	Open C:\xampp\apache\logs\error.log, or temporarily add display_errors = On in php.ini
Vietnamese text shows as ???	Wrong character set	The database and the connection must both use utf8mb4 / utf8mb4_unicode_ci
Images or documents do not upload	The uploads folder is missing or read-only	Create the uploads folder and give it write permission

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F. UNINSTALL

1. Delete the folder **C:\xampp\htdocs\legalease**.
2. Open phpMyAdmin, select the database **legalproject1**, choose the **Operations** tab and click **Drop the database (DROP)**.
3. Stop Apache and MySQL from the XAMPP Control Panel.

Installation completed. After Step 5 the LegalEase platform is fully running on the local machine and every function described in the User Guide can be tested.

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